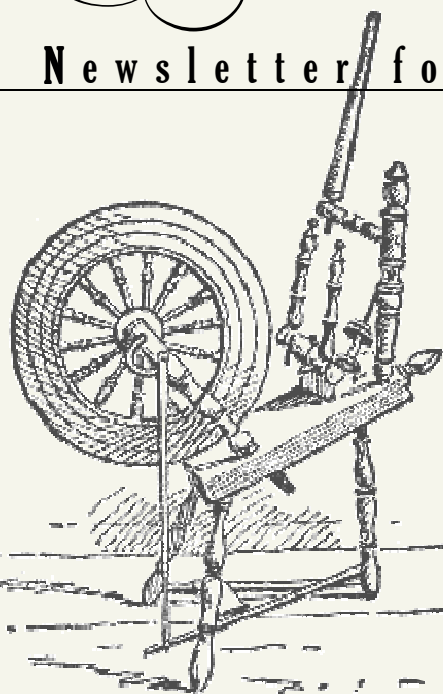


Hollerbeier Haven

Newsletter for the Herbal and Healing Arts



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With Groundhog Day we are reminded that the winter is waning and spring is on its way. It's time to lift our minds up from our winter hibernation, and return to the green world of the coming spring with the teachings we gained in the dark time of the year.

At the Three Sisters Center, we have undergone profound transformations during the winter season. Though we missed all of your smiling faces, the time off from conducting guild meetings allowed us the down time we needed to reshape, regroup, and revision for the coming year.

With the onset of winter came two new apprentices. Jesse's apprentice this year is Patrick Donmoyer, and Matthew's apprentice is his sister, Lauren Sicher. Both Patrick and Lauren are contributing to the Three Sisters Project in new and exciting ways. Lauren has undertaken the enormous task of transcribing the many interviews of Brauchers gathered by Dennis Boyer (Jesse's teacher) that we had safely stored away. Lauren is not only transcribing, but also filing, organizing, and indexing the information from each and every interview, making this wisdom more easily accessible to us.

Patrick is assisting in developing the 'Braucherei Weg' distance course. His familiarity with the technological equipment necessary for recording will help greatly with this process. He is also a student of the Kabala and Rune work and will be sharing much of this knowledge with us this year. Both Lauren and Patrick will be the new faces at our meetings and classes, helping things to run more smoothly, and we are very glad to have them!

During the winter season Susan formulated a new series of herbal workshops and weed walks for 2008 that will complement her 'Homestead Herbalism' course. She has taken on the role as editor of the 'Hollerbeier Haven' newsletter and continues to refine her publishing skills with every issue. A few of her goals this year are to begin a series of fraktur-style paintings of useful native Pennsylvania plants and to complete a color poster version of the Deitsch Medicine Wheel. She also plans to attend Jesse's 'Braucherei Weg' course and many of the Guild Gatherings.

Jesse has been steadily preparing the curriculum for the first year of her 'Braucherei Weg' course as well as the Guild Gatherings schedule. This year the course and Guild meetings will be held at the Kutztown Area Historical Society. In addition to this ongoing work, Jesse, along with Patrick, will be undertaking a new course of study as they begin formal training in Medieval Astrology with Robert Zoller of Project Hindsight in Cumberland, MD.

Through all of these many changes we have found ourselves strengthened and energized for the new year. Our common goal of revival of the Braucherei tradition and of our Pennsylvania Deitsch culture drives each of us towards a greater understanding of our own piece of this project.

-Blessings, Jesse and Susan





The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts is recording stories, interviews, memories, and knowledge of the healing traditions of Pow-wow or Braucherei. We are creating an archive of this tradition in order to preserve our heritage and ensure the practice. If you know anyone who practices or has a story to tell, we'd love to hear from you; whether you'd like to give a personal interview or prefer to remain anonymous, simply write to us. Your personal experiences are culturally valuable and will be treated with the utmost respect. You can contact us with questions or information by writing to:

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Meet two new members of the *Three Sisters Center Family!*

Lauren Sicher is a serious student of the PA German culture and language. She is currently pursuing her bachelor's degree through Prescott College. Lauren has studied the language and culture of her people, and has recently committed herself to the Braucherei Path. She is apprenticing with her brother, Matthew Sicher, and taking the *Braucherei Weg* course this year. Lauren has undertaken a great challenge during her apprenticeship: she is transcribing the interviews of over 80 Braucherei practitioners, and organizing the information in a coherent way so that it is of use to the work of the Three Sisters Center in the future. We, at the Three Sisters Center are very grateful for her commitment to this important task.

Patrick Donmoyer currently lives in the Kutztown area while working towards a BFA in Studio Art and a BFA in Fine Crafts at Kutztown University, with concentrations in printmaking and textiles, respectively. He is also working towards a minor in PA German Studies. His artwork attempts to reflect on occult and religious symbolism of the past and present. His research has primarily focused on restoration of early 19th century carpet looms as well as developing a photographic survey of the historic hex signs of Berks County, Pennsylvania. He currently works and studies at the PA German Cultural Heritage Center in Kutztown. He has also committed himself to the Braucherei Path this year and is apprenticing with Jesse Tobin

A decorative floral border with various flowers and leaves, framing the title and author information.

The Flame of the Spirit at Lichtmess

by Jesse Tobin

Lichtmess, the festival of lights is the celebration of the sacred creative power of the feminine. In ancient times this season celebrated the birth of lambs among the flocks of sheep. In modern times perhaps this seems to be a strange event to celebrate. To our ancestors, though, it meant that fresh milk was available as a food source after the grueling months of dried foods and meats. The festival of Lichtmess also celebrated the coming spring, for though the days were still cold, they were growing longer, to be followed close behind by the warmth of the spring sun.

February 2nd has been sacred to many saints and goddesses, among them are Brigid, Mary, and Sophia. It is a time to see the potential of the creative forces of feminine energy, to feel the stirring in the womb, and to prepare for birth. It is also the time of the Grundsau (Groundhog) Moon, and the solar sign of Aquarius. The Groundhog's central presence in our modern celebration of Lichtmess (or Groundhog day as most of us know it) is only an echo of the more ancient Dachsaag (Badger day). It is a time to hear the messages of other world travelers, of the saints, angels, and goddesses. It is a time of prophecy for the coming year of green growth, giving us knowledge of the approaching season, allowing us time for preparation.

Ceremony surrounding the Lichtmess among the Deutsch centered, like every other aspect of life, on agriculture. Lichtmess was the time of the blessing of the fields, again, preparing for the birth that will come in due time, and inviting the good fortune of a healthy crop. Beyond the well-known weather divination of the groundhog, there is much to be done in this season. The sheaves of corn saved from the first harvest of the grain in August would have been kept until this time. During Lichtmess the sheaves would have been fashioned into the "Butzeman", or scarecrow for the coming year. This Butzeman would then be placed in the fields, not only to guard over the new grain to come, but to return the spirit of the grain to the earth, just as the spirit comes to the womb along with the seed to make a child whole. The first milking of the ewes, goats, or cows would have been poured out on the fields, giving nourishment, and the blessings of the mother to the fields and the spirits of the crops.

Lichtmess was also a time of cleaning and purification. Traditionally this was the time of "switching over" the fire. The hearth fire kept a nearly constant burn throughout the turn of the year for the cooking and warmth of the home. At Lichtmess the fire was allowed to burn out. The hearth was cleansed and purified, and the fire was started anew with flint, and often with at least some birch wood for purification. This was a time of frenzied cleaning for most female Brauchers, as the heart and the home must be open and clear to receive the blessings to come.

Often the Earth was associated with the Virgin Sophia, and she took on many of the attributes of the sign of Virgo, the sacred virgin of the Grain harvest. The association here goes even deeper, though, at Lichtmess, to the very story of Sophia herself. With the knowledge of her story, this is not only a celebration of the coming spring, or the return of the light, it is a celebration of the spark of divinity in our own hearts: the light of our souls. Sophia helps us to recognize that light, and to focus on its potential for growth. This season brings potential and it is a time to be quiet and listen to the voice of wisdom in our spirits. Deep prayer and meditation is the purpose of the Feast of Lights, when the mother shows us our potential growth for the coming year, the path we should tread. It is her inspiration that can set the candles of Lichtmess to a flame of spirit in our hearts. We need only to quiet the chatter of the mundane and listen.

Sophia, Creator of the Dutch

She has had many faces, many stories, many songs. Sophia has been with us long. The variations of her story are as plentiful as the people who have told them, and there will be more. She shows herself to each of us uniquely. How remarkable are the sparks of light she has whispered into these bodies. Each its own, yet reflecting the whole, and reflecting a whole that is beyond the whole: that which we cannot comprehend in any way beyond the personal knowledge of the light within.

The story given here is only one of many, the story as it flows through one heart and soul, yet as true as any other. The Gnostic sects began well before the time of Jesus of Nazareth. There has never been a cohesive whole, never an official church of Gnosticism, only schools of thought and collections of individuals. Gnosticism is a loosely woven tradition that incorporated many of the teachings and mythologies of other religions, whether Pagan or Christian, Gentile or Jew. It is a tradition that fit well among those who could not stomach the standard teachings of the Roman church, and there were many who fit that description.

After the council of Niceaea, the Gnostic gospels and doctrine were deemed heretical. The story of Sophia is the basis of the Gnostic faith, and it is one that is often seen as being at odds with standard doctrine of the Roman church. In the early days of Christianity, it was the few who attempted to merge the two traditions who were attacked most vehemently, some losing their lives, others only their credibility. Despite intense persecution of Gnostic believers for centuries by the Roman church, and the many heretical purgings in Europe and the Middle East, Gnosticism has survived, buried within the folds of folk belief and in the minds of silent heretics.

Nearly all of the Christian mystics of Europe who have influenced the Braucherei tradition have held strong elements of Gnosticism in their doctrines and teachings. Many of these mystics contributed strongly to the folk faith of the German people, and especially to the healing and spiritual system that has come to be known as Braucherei. Strong undercurrents of Gnostic belief flowed through much of the folk faith of Europe, though few knew it by that name. Among the German mystics who contributed to the preservation of Gnosticism and the development of Braucherei spirituality are: Hildegard von Bingen, Meister Eckhart, Mechthilde of Magdeburg, Johannes Tauler, Mechthilde of Hackenborn, Cornelius Heinrich Agrippa, Paracelsus, Jacob Boehme, etc. By the time of the reformation some elements had become so entrenched in the mystical tradition of the German people that it had become theirs in truth, fully integrated into folk belief, and nearly stronger than church doctrine. The pietical movement has its roots in this tradition, as does Luther's reformation. Not surprisingly many elements continue in Pennsylvania German culture, and especially in healing and spiritual tradition of Braucherei.

This, then is her story.....

Before time began nothing and everything were one and the same. There was no "creation" and no "creator" there was only the great vastness of more than is imaginable. There is no comprehending it. This being of boundlessness has been known by many names. "Bythos" (Depth), "Aion teleos" (perfect Aeon), and "Proarkhe" (before the beginning) are only a few of the words wielded by human tongues to give form to this vastness.

Bythos had a desire to express its own vastness, and found no way to do so. It held such immense visions and longings, imaginings of light, sound, and matter, but all was held within. Eventually, like the slow waking from a deep sleep, there was a realization that these dreams were beings unto themselves, and that they longed to be released to their paths. I think we cannot imagine the tender love and feelings of loss, the hope and excitement, the worry and longing that Bythos felt as it released itself, allowing the great imaginings to find a form of separateness.

The light, sound and explosion of spirit that came in this moment is still remembered in the furthest reaches of every soul, the very first moment of existence. The first emanation from Bythos was another being. In contrast to the abyss of Bythos she was swathed in light. It was not until this moment that Bythos became "he" and his emanation, "she". Before she was separate there was only the wholeness of one, now there were two who longed toward each other in a passion to create.

This being of light has also had many names. She is known as: "Barbelo", "Ennoia" (thought), "Charis" (grace), and "Sige" (Silence). Again these are few examples of the many names she is given by the peoples of Earth.

They began to create other beings. These new beings came out in pairs of lover-siblings, twins, male and female. Each pair completed itself. Each pair after the last found itself further and further from the perfect vastness of Bythos. Each was more and more specific and exact, losing the flighty, nebulous nature of Bythos and Barbelo as they uncoiled across the universe. Yet each had its place, and the heavens held a balance only when each kept its place and fulfilled its own imaginings and dreams. There were twelve pairs before the last.

The youngest and fiercest of these beings, called Aeons, was most beautiful as well. She was radiant with light and powerful intention. She was also the wildest and most impulsive. When Sophia was born she did not wait for her partner. Her purpose and impatience drove her from her moment of birth. The potential of her imaginings stretched out before her and she ran to catch them, allowing nothing to slow her progress, not even her consort. Continued on page 8...

SPRING CLEANING *by Susan Hess*

The longer days may soon bring you a fleeting opportunity to throw open a door or window to air out a room or a maybe a sudden but welcome chance to use the outside wash line instead of the electric dryer. The slightest shift in seasonal awareness can awaken us with a whisper. This morning I heard the gentle warble of a returning bluebird. His familiar song suddenly gave me enough reason to leave the chore I was doing and go outside and greet him with a whistle. That tiny, energetic, spark of blue against the brown of sleeping gardens and pasture was such a subtle observation, but it stirred pleasure and hope into my winter weary being.

In turning back towards the warm house, I noticed that it was time to remove the tired winter evergreens that graced the porch and door in the days leading up to Christmas. Removing the greens left a fragrant trail of dry needles that soon prompted me to give the whole porch a good sweeping with the broom. A bucket with a little hot water and homemade soap helped to wash away the stubborn muddy footprints that are laced with salt and sunflower seeds from the bird feeder.

On my way to the fire pit to burn the greens and the Christmas fir tree, I passed by the lavender bed that hold 18 large, although scraggly, bushes. They are showing the slightest change of color in their branches; yet another subtle whisper that says 'time to prune and clean up that bed'. While the greens burned, I sharpened my pruning shears and soon began feeding piles of spent flower branches to the fire. The lavender scent reminds me of the floral rewards I will reap in June if I give a good haircut today. I walked away, admiring the newly pruned mounds of lavender and the smoldering fire pit, woodsy pine and lavender oils still lingering in the air.

When I reached the porch I gave a last sweet glimpse to a freshly cleaned porch still wet with tiny soap bubbles before going through the door.

While I know our PA German foremothers may have had a more disciplined

schedule when it came to spring housecleaning, I prefer to be moved by a spontaneous nudge, a slight shift in the weather, or a breeze that 'asks' to dry my sheets.

The result of listening to these natural 'spring welcoming' impulses makes way for a clean start or a fresh slate, even if it resides in a small corner of one room. 'Removing the cobwebs', 'sweeping away the old' and 'letting in fresh air' are all metaphors for new beginnings in an uncluttered house or mind.

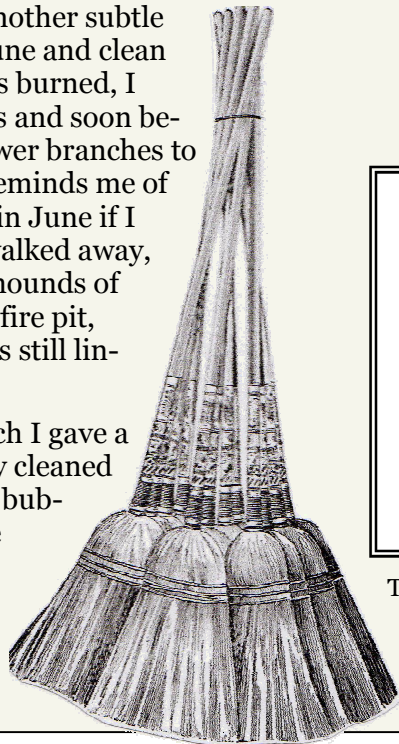
And although I never *planned* to follow the sound of a bluebird warble, the simple act of it returned me, renewed and refreshed to a chore that I was not enjoying when I left. The mundane acts of sweeping, burning, pruning and mopping, while inhaling the fresh fragrant air outdoors, cleared my head as well as it cleared my surroundings. I was able to return to my project with uplifted spirit and a new outlook which hastened its completion. What a vastly different perspective with just a little 'simple spring cleaning'.

Continued on page 16...

From 'Beliefs and Superstitions of the
Pennsylvania Germans' (1915)
by Edwin Miller Fogel, Ph.D.

En grossi Fraa un en
grossi Scheier sin kem
Mann ken Schaade.!

Translation to be found somewhere within the
pages of this newsletter!!





Voices of the Elders

The voices of unknown people scrawl across the paper, giving words to their memories. The writing is abbreviated, leaving much to the imagination. The faces, the voices, the people are unknown. Only their words of incantations, amulets, and history of themselves remain. The possibilities are endless. Only the initials of each elder, their church denomination, and sometimes their home gives any semblance of understanding of the person themselves. The task is to decipher the meanings, whether it is divined from the messy handwriting or from the words that, even when legible, sometimes make little sense.

Transcribing is the task; but that word does not do the process justice. Though typing from original documents there is more to it. That piece of paper: crinkled, messy writing, lined paper, or torn edges holds a story. Not just any story, but a history. It is a history that is this place, a history that unfolds itself from our home.

Braucherei is the link between each of these memories, stories, and people. Braucherei is the history, the tradition, a part of us. Our ancestors, the ancestors of this place, have kept these words on their lips, these thoughts in their minds for centuries. Looking at these papers I am elated with the information that is written on them. I know that as this tradition fades from the minds and lips of those elders who are passing, I am one of few who strive to keep it alive, to hold these sacred words in my hand, heart, and mind. It is difficult to draw the lines in this work, though. This tradition is oral and I am writing down and clarifying what I can. But right now that is what needs to be done to keep the words of the elders alive, breathing, and in the forefront of this culture's mind. I only will share these documents with the people who I know can respect, understand, and appreciate the honor of carrying these truths, and keep them as they have been kept since the dawn of the practice. To others I will share ideas and concepts from these papers to create curiosity, interest, or to invite a lost memory to resurface. That is what I will share with you in this column in each newsletter.

In my transcriptions I came across a wide variety of things. There were plenty of interviews about peoples' experiences and ideas. Some experiences came from a family member, or friend being powwowed. Sometimes the person being interviewed saw a Braucher themselves. These experiences varied in age and different backgrounds: Amish, UCC, Methodist, or Lutheran. The interviews were conducted in places like Reamstown, Albany Township, New Tripoli, Bernville, Macungie, all places steeped heavily in the ways and words of the PA German people.

One of my first transcriptions was about the moon. There were cures, charms, and dreams that were discussed. Some of it was activities that should be done in different moon phases and other bits were about what certain colors or phases meant. One document was all about numbers in groups of threes and what they meant. The woman referred to it as: "Number signs in Threes" and "Trinitarian Work". I personally was not aware of this part of Braucherei. Another writing contained ideas that went along with barn stars or hex signs. It told a slight history along with ideas on their meanings and involvement with Pow-wow. I really enjoyed a transcription that was all harvest prayers for things like crops, fishing, hunting, and a few other things. For the longest time I've wanted to find a prayer for those things. The one titled Male/Female Instruction talked about passing the tradition to the opposite sex and different ways it was done. Some townships had more of a rule that kept it within the family like aunt to nephew and others decided it shouldn't be a family member. The part that I've heard before but still fascinated me was what the person called 'finding a dream child'. It was amazing for me to see at least three accounts on this topic saying "I was dreamt of by my teacher." There was one document that was very interesting to me but was harder for me to follow. It was talking about some of the history of Pow-wow and what events happened. A man named Dr. Bruno was mentioned from around the 1500's who had a group that eventually turned into the Rosicrucians. This went into events of the middle ages. Legends of "royal blood" came about along with secret orders that were for men and women. I found this all very interesting. I'd really like to do some more research into it and shed some more light on these events and ideas.

We are always learning more, always finding more, always deepening our understanding of our Braucherei Path. I hope that all of you, like us, continue to watch this unfolding flower with excitement and anticipation.

By Lauren Sicher

Yggdrasil and the Origins of the Runes— by Patrick Donmoyer

We must begin our story in a place familiar to us all, Midgard, the earthly realm of humankind. As its name suggests, it is the half-way point between the realms of the gods and the underworld. Spanning and bisecting this universal divide is the mighty Ash tree Yggdrasil, forming a vertical trunk to connect earth to the heavens and the depths. The branches of this tree of life form a canopy and support Asgard, the home of the gods. Urdabrun, the well of fate, can be found here guarded by the goddesses of destiny, Urdur, or the past, Verdandi, or the present, Skuld, or the Future. The roots reach deep into the well called Hvergelmir, the source of all rivers. Beneath the roots lies the underworld, Niflheim. The periphery surrounding Midgard is Jotunheim, the realm of the frost giants from which springs the well of wisdom and understanding, knowledge and prophesy, poetry and language, called Mimisbrun. This all encompassing tree of life formed a conduit between the worlds, connecting, and consolidating the universe into a single living entity, Yggdrasil. It is from Yggdrasil that the powerful warrior creator god Wotan first beheld the Runes, a sacred alphabet used to describe and interpret the complexities of life.

In one of the *Eddas*, or sacred poetic writings of the Norse peoples, there is a story of Wotan's discovery of the runes:

I hung from a windswept tree.
I hung there for nine days and nights,
Gashed with a spear,
An offering to Odin,
A sacrifice to myself,
Bonded to the tree which no man knows,
Or whither its roots may run.

No-one gave me bread,
Nor gave me drink.
I peered down into the depths and
Snatched up the runes,
And with a fearful scream
Fell into a swoon.

After I began to thrive,
My wisdom thrived too.
I was joyful and I prospered.
One word led me to another,
One deed led me to another.

"Speech of the High One"
The Poetic Edda, c. 1200 AD

In this passage, Odin seeks wisdom and transformation, and suspends himself upside-down from one of the branches of Yggdrasil, remaining there with nothing for sustenance until a vision awakens him. As leaves have fallen from the heights of Yggdrasil, he sees the sacred runes lying in the depths. When he understands these signs fully, he finds the

parallel between action and thought, representation and manifestation. These characters form the basis for written language by which man and god can abstractly represent, describe and influence reality. One can easily see a parallel between Odin's self-sacrifice and Christ's crucifixion, however rather than humans sacrificing a son of god to unite humans with the divine, Odin sought to sacrifice himself in order to unite all reality within the awareness of the all encompassing Yggdrasil. This wisdom and awareness of interconnectedness is concentrated into the characters of the runes.

The Germanic Runes are seen as the oldest form of this ancient writing. There are 24 runes, and they are called the Futhark, after the first 6 runes (F-U-Th-A-R-K) of the system. The Table of Runes with this article provides each rune with a rough approximation of its English equivalent. Our knowledge of the Runes is derived mainly from an ancient Anglo-Saxon poem that describes each Rune by name, and offers some interpretation as to their meaning and use. (This poem will be included in next issue of HH.) Most Runes are called by names of elemental forces, such as Sigel, the sun; or Is, the ice; Lagu, the water. Others are the names of sacred trees, such as Yr, the Yew; Beorc, the Birch. Although these characters have been and continue to be used a writing system in a traditional sense, Runes tend to be valued more for their symbolic content and their applications in divination and magic. Runes were worn as protective emblems, and the wooden framing of Germanic homes was often intentionally patterned after the runes to invoke their power and protection. The most common application of this sacred system is in divination, whereby the runes are scribed onto a type of object, either bones, sticks, stones, ceramic or any number of objects than can carry an individual Rune. These objects carrying the Runes are allowed to fall from the hand of the user, and significance and understanding can be drawn from the patterns that emerge.

This understanding of the runes will be discussed in great length and will be the primary focus of the Runic articles appearing in the next issues of the Hollerbeier Haven newsletter. This will be an attempt to provide the groundwork for the learning and application of this tradition for those seeking a greater understanding of the Tree of Life and its secrets.

Germanic Runes *The Futhark*

F	U	Th	A	R	K	G	W
H	N	I	J	Ei	P	Z	S
T	B	E	M	L	N	g	D
O	e						

Sophia continued from page 4...

As she moved she caught sight of the most brilliant light she had yet seen among the specter of all of her siblings: she caught sight of her parents. The light of her mother was bound up in the abyss of her father and she wanted that light, she plunged ahead to find it, to unite with it, to make it hers. She only vaguely heard the calls of her siblings that warned of her danger. In the arrogance of her youth she ignored these limitations that would hold others back. Their calls only served to spur her forward, toward the light and the vast depth of the abyss.

As she moved she ripped the balance of the cosmos. She tore from her place, and broke the peace of the heavens as she pulled and tugged at her own fate in a way that none before her had. As she reached out to grasp hold of the light, to embrace Barbelo, the abyss surrounding her swallowed Sophia in its vastness, and she was falling.

At first the light was brighter, but as she fell the light fell away from it with increasing speed. The light of her siblings was gone, her parents were slipping away, and before she fell into complete darkness she saw the faintest glimmer of her brother-lover Christ. The glimpse she caught was enough to turn her mistake into true mourning.

When she was fully swathed in darkness, when she was utterly alone she fought against her fear and sadness. If she could not have the light of her parents, and if she could not have her consort, she would create a companion. And so she did, she created a son. He was born from her, however, without the perfect union of her lover, and so he was an empty thing. Born of anguish and sadness, he did not hold the purpose or intention of her siblings, he was hollow, a half being. She was ashamed as soon as she'd created him. She named him Ialdabaoth "son of shame", and wrapped him in a swath of fog so that he could not see her, or know from whence he came. So that he could not know his own shame, but be content in himself as he was.

Before he was engulfed in the mist, however, he caught sight of her radiant beauty. He beheld for one instant the light of her spirit, and he wanted it. He wanted it like she had wanted the light of her mother. Ialdabaoth reached out and took hold of his mother and tore her light away from her. Sophia leapt back in pain and found herself in chaos again. She fell away, further into the depths as she mourned the loss of her light and beauty.

From the distance she watched as young son declared on his throne in the midst of the fog: "It is I who am God, and there was no God before me". With this declaration he set about creating the material world and heavens. He created angels to help him in his work, and as he worked he saw the face of Sophia reflected on the vast waters he had made. With her face in his mind he set about creating human kind "in the image of God". As Sophia watched Ialdabaoth piecing together the lumps of clay, she had an idea. When the form of Adam was assembled he still had no life or spirit, and Ialdabaoth was deeply sad. Sophia whispered into the ear of one of her son's angels,

saying that Ialdabaoth should take some of the light that he held and blow the light into the body of Adam.

He did this, and Adam lived. When he created Eve he did the same. He very quickly realized, though, that these two he had created were as brilliant and wondrous as his mother had been. He felt shame for one of his creation to be better than him, and he feared that they might learn of Sophia, so he created false souls for them, and cloaked the brilliance of his mother's light with this mantle.

Sophia descended into the earth, following her light, and lived among the people. Sometimes as a spirit or a goddess, sometimes as a mortal woman. She was drawn to her own light, kept tight inside the souls of the humans, and it was torture to be near them, and it was torture to be away. She was trapped in the earthly realm; she was confused, mournful, and terrified. More than anything else she was ashamed, and when the shame was too great she cried out, wept, and sang to release it from her soul. She called out for help and lost herself in her grief. She thought she would die from the loss of the light.

When she had given in completely, given herself over to death, to utter loss, it was at that moment that she first saw the brightness descending upon her.

When he first came to her she was afraid, ashamed that he would see what she had done and despise her. When he did not look away, but only came closer, warming her with his light, she realized the truth of their perfect union, and she gave herself over to him and wept in relief and joy. She had lived so many lives of shame, and all the pain of it she had borne alone. He held her pain with a tenderness that freed her of it and released her from the weighted existence of the earthly realm.

The love and perfection of their reunion filled her heart with a light that was not hers. Her own light was in the hearts of the earthly realm, and would remain there to guide humankind. The light she received was not her own, true, but it gave her buoyancy and she escaped the realm of matter to wait in the heavens. Her lover came to her in the earthly realm as Jesus Christ. He came to release her as he came to show a way to us. Just as he cannot save her from her own fate, and can only show her the way, it is the same for us. In truth, her fate and ours are one and the same, for we hold her spirit beneath our skin. In the earthly realm as in the heavens, it is our choice of the path to take.

Since the time of Jesus, many have come to remind us of our task. The task stands as follows: we are born to this earth endowed with a spark of the divine light within our souls. It is our duty and our purpose to grow this spark of light until it engulfs our entire beings.

It is not that Christ will come again to the earth, it is that the earth will rise to meet Christ as each heart and soul swells with the glory and brilliance that is our birthright. It is a duty that only we can fulfill, to follow the "book of the human heart", our own inner light, to cast off this false soul and return home.

Continued on page 9...

Sophia continued from page 8...

The story and understanding of Sophia has been carried on in the Braucherei tradition. Her face shines through to us in many ways. She is called "Saint Sophia" or "Sophia, creator of the Dutch". She is seen in the form of the three sisters of Braucherei, collectively called "Sophia". Here she merges with the weaving Norns of ancient Germanic tradition. She is three beings here, united in one: the young girl who falls from her father's house; the mother in body and spirit to us all, her spirit coursing through the very earth to grow our grain; and the wise old crone, the elder who speaks wisdom to our hearts and guides us, should we care to listen. In this form she is seen as the female trinity, she balances the male trinity of the "three highest names". Some Brauchers will meditate upon her ever-changing faces to read what is to be done in a healing, or to convey the energies of her wisdom and wholeness to another. Some Brauchers will invoke her names in balance to the names of the male trinity to seal their prayers.

As in Germanic mythology, she is guardian of the web of fate. She is outside of it, greater than it, yet she is the web itself as well. The Pennsylvania Germans love Sophia. We can see her face in architecture, fraktur paintings, and gravestones. We can hear the prayers to her and the love of her in countless German writings. In the work of Jacob Boehme and the writings, songs and artwork of the Ephrata Cloister, in the music of the Moravians, and the prayers of a farmer, she is with us. She is often depicted as an angel or a saint. The virgin Sophia in some cases is the personification of the people's ties to their land. Her spirit is present throughout all of creation, and only in union with all of creation can we be whole.

William Woys Weaver quoted his grandfather in his book "Pennsylvania Dutch Country Cooking". This song is not unique in its veneration of mother earth, for she was as sacred to the Dietsch as Jesus himself. These words portray perfectly the way that Sophia's memory has been kept alive in the words and actions of everyday:

"Honor the mother who
carried you near to her
heart;

Honor the soil from
which she has molded the
land;

Honor the bread that she
brings forth from the
womb of the Earth"

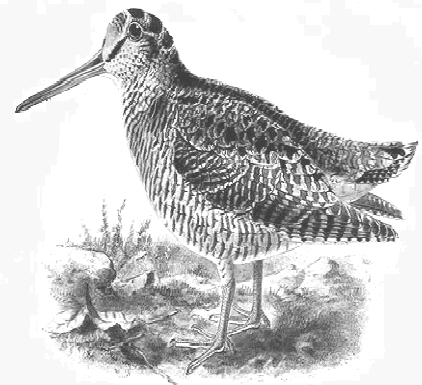
Planting Seeds and Bursting Forth

The crocus and snow drops are bursting forth into bright arrays of color, animals are returning from their winter hideaways, the young sun is warming our backs. The spring equinox has arrived with a bustle of activity. With the equinox on March 20th comes the official beginning of the spring season. The energy of this solar festival is masculine, active, and expansive, directing us to put into action those things we wish to see in the coming year.

Traditionally this is a time of plowing. According to the old ways we are to plow, prepare beds, or plant only when the moon is in the signs of Aries, Gemini, Leo, Sagittarius, and Aquarius. Most of the crops planted at this time of the year are planted inside, as seedlings in trays, but from these tiny sprouts will come the fruitful plants of the high summer. Likewise the seeds we plant in the world of action and spirit will come to full growth in due time... so plant well and wisely!

According to Braucherei tradition the Butzeman should be taken from his place overlooking the gardens and fields, and should be paraded around all of the fields of the farmstead.

At each of the cardinal directions the Braucher is to pause, and make prayers for the growth and health of his crops, livestock, and family.



The Holzhaahne Muun (Woodcock moon) begins with the equinox, along with the sun sign of Aries. The Holzhaahne signifies the resourcefulness of the spring. He teaches us to adapt to our environment. He shows us an end to the hunger and stagnancy of winter foods with the fresh spring greens that are beginning to sprout forth. He also teaches us the lesson of speed and timeliness of action. The fickle young spring can be warm and easy as often as it is snowy and cold. The Holzhaahne teaches us to plough when the sun is shining, and not to take opportunities for granted at this early time in the year.

SUSAN'S SPRING TONIC SOUP

1 bunch of leeks, cleaned and chopped (white part only)
2 carrots, grated
1-2 cloves garlic minced
2-3 TB butter
2 quarts good chicken broth (or water)
1 cup oat flakes
Salt and pepper to taste
large colander full of spring nettle tops
large handful of young dandelion greens
(or other assorted other wild greens: a few small violet leaves,
chickweed, garlic grass, garlic mustard greens, dock greens, etc.)



Sauté leeks, carrots, and garlic in butter until soft.

Cover with chicken broth and bring to a simmer.

Add oat flakes, stir and cover.

While broth is simmering, gather a pair of scissors and a colander or bowl and harvest your greens.

To avoid the inevitable sting of the stinging nettles, snip the tops off with the scissors and allow them to drop right into the colander.

Use the scissors to cut the tops into smaller pieces while they are still in the bowl.

The snipped nettle tops can go directly into the soup pot.

If the other greens are muddy, be sure to rinse them in cool water.

Chop and add to the soup. Let simmer slightly until the greens are limp but serve while the greens are still vibrant in color.

HOT BACON DRESSING

1 egg, well beaten
1/3 cup sugar
1/4 cup cider vinegar
3/4 cup water
1/2 teaspoon salt
4 strips bacon, cut into 1 inch pieces
1 tablespoon flour



Beat the sugar into the egg. Add the vinegar, water and salt; beat well. Meanwhile, brown the bacon in small saucepan. Stir the flour into the bacon and drippings until smooth. Add the liquid to the bacon mixture and cook over medium heat until thickened, stirring constantly. Serve over dandelion greens, endive or cooked cabbage



Interesting Historical Facts and Folklore

*Blowing on the dandelion seed heads was once considered a way to reveal the time of day; as many times as it takes to blow all the seeds away is also the time. If it took 3 blows to free all of the fluff, it was close to 3:00. Another three-blow belief is that if a child can blow away all the seeds away in three tries (or less), his mother does not want him at home, but if it takes more than three huffs and puffs, he better get home...NOW!

*It was also strongly believed that dandelions served as weather forecasters. If they do not open in the morning, it will rain. Or, if the down flies off the seed heads even though there is no wind, it will storm later in the day. *Another belief has it that the tallest dandelion a child can find will be equivalent to the number of inches that child will grow in the coming year. *The milky white latex found in the stem of the dandelion can be applied daily to warts with the promise that it will fall off before frost comes.

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DANDELION

Taraxacum officinalis

Lion's tooth, piss-a-bett

Dandelions were introduced into European medicine by the Arabs who were extolling its virtues as early as the 10th century. The shape of the leaves explains the French name: *dents de lion* or “teeth of the lion”. *Piss-a-bett* comes from the leaves exceptional diuretic abilities.

Traditional medicinal uses: The bitter compounds of both the leaf and root of the dandelion stimulate the appetite and promote proper digestion. This includes stimulating the entire digestive tract, including the liver and gall bladder and has a slight laxative effect on the intestines.

Dandelion root is considered to be an old time “blood purifier.” Apparently it was a common local custom (Reading, PA) around the turn of the 20th century to carry a bit of dried dandelion root in your pocket and nibble on it a few times a day “to keep healthy” Today we know dandelion as one of the best liver herbs. Helps with sluggish bowel/chronic constipation. Stimulates bile secretions, small intestine enzymes & pancreatic enzymes which are essential for digestion and nutrient absorption. Useful for any liver distress from: rich food, drug or alcohol abuse, gallstones,

Helps liver and kidneys improve elimination— may improve acne and eczema-like skin conditions. Regulates hormone balance, lowers cholesterol and triglyceride levels. . Very safe for children with constipation. Dandelion leaf can be safely taken as a tea to help reduce water weight gain or edema in the legs . It acts as a superb diuretic that does not deplete potassium, thus may help regulate high blood pressure. Best taken long term.

Extremely nutritious wild green!! Incredibly rich source of minerals, vitamins B&C and calcium. Best to harvest in early spring before flowering. In the summer, they are *very* bitter.

SPINNING THE FLAX TALE by Susan Hess

Flax (*Linum usitatissimum*) was formerly one of the most useful and productive crops of the Pennsylvania countryside, but its' presence as such, has sadly dissolved into history and legend. At one time, flax was one of the state's earliest agricultural exported items but cultivation in Pennsylvania ceased almost entirely by 1870, having been in gradual decline since the civil war. The introduction of cheaper cotton goods were also introduced about the same time.

Flax seed was sown early in the spring and by early summer the field was awash with a sea of brilliant blue flowers on long slender stalks that swayed easily in the breeze. By the time it was harvested late in the summer, the plants were in seed and ready to be pulled up by hand. They were then stacked on the ground to be rained upon or soaked in a nearby stream to hasten the decomposition of the outer layer of the stalk. This 'retting' process would dissolve the natural glue which binds the flax fibers to the stalk. After the outer skin had rotted, the flax stalks had to be dried again. Depending on the weather this may have happened out in the fields or possibly near a fire. A series of repetitive processes followed that involved 'breaking' the outer stalk and separating the long fibers for spinning. Up until this point all the diligent physical preparations that accompanied planting and harvest were the mainly the responsibility of the men folk. The finished raw flax fibers were then carefully stored in a dry place until they were brought out again during the long dark nights that followed.

Spinning was a winter chore performed by the women and girls of the household. An old proverb in the Pennsylvania German dialect was: "Lichtmess, schpinna fergess" which meant that all the winter spinning needed to be completed and the spools full of flax thread by Candelmas day which was February 2nd. When the spinning was completed, the thread was then sent to the local weaver who produced the linen cloth. The weaver was most often a man, who would likely keep a portion of the cloth as payment for his services. It was rare for an 18th century household to have their own full-sized loom. These were very large and expensive pieces of equipment and were generally owned and operated by those who were weavers by trade. Many households did have a small table or hand loom that could produce a long narrow measure of cloth that was useful for smaller household needs. The total production time from pressing the seed into the cold wet soil to completion of a soft warm undergarment could take up to eighteen months or more.

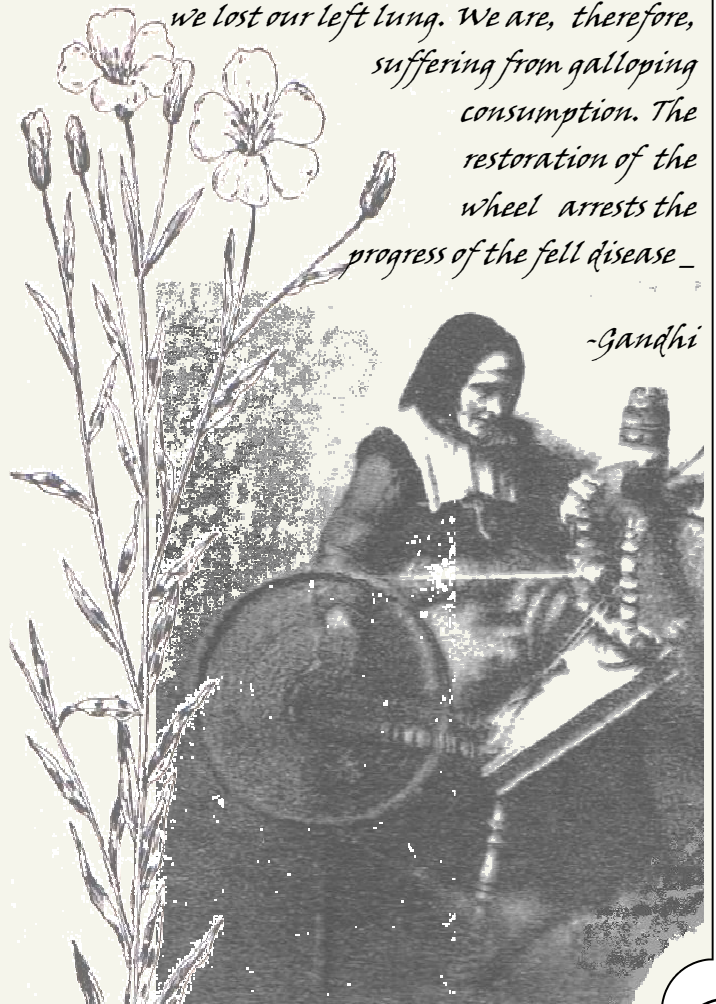
The history of 'Flaxbaue' (or flax culture) dates back to the late Stone Age. Archeological excavations around earthen dwellings in Switzerland show that the inhabitants there were familiar with linen. Through the ages, linen was used not only to make garments, but also to make great sails for shipping vessels, rope and cording, nets for hunting and fishing, lamp wicks, as well as for making pages for books and manuscripts. Linen was so important that it was used as actual currency in some northern regions.

Though the blue flax flowers were often associated with the Virgin Mary during medieval times, this was surely a holdover from earlier cultures who understood the flax 'creation stories' to be linked with the various 'spinning goddesses'. The goddesses (Holle, Hulda, Frigg, Brigit, Perchta, and the Wyrd Sisters) were charged with the gifting of the flax seeds to mortals,

Continued on page 15...

*I claim that in losing the spinning wheel
we lost our left lung. We are, therefore,
suffering from galloping
consumption. The
restoration of the
wheel arrests the
progress of the fell disease -*

-Gandhi



"From 'Nanny's Remedy Book'"

Mustard Plaster

The person receiving the treatment should sit or lie down comfortably. The most effective plasters are made with black mustard seeds, freshly ground in a coffee grinder, but plain yellow mustard powder will do in a pinch.

Mix one ½ cup mustard powder with 1 cup flour and stir hot water into the mixture to form a loose paste.

Spread the mixture evenly out on a piece of white cotton, flannel or muslin yardage that has been soaked in warm water. Cover with a second piece of heavier fabric that is dry. Cover exposed nipples (male or female!) with a thick layer of lard or Vaseline and a thick cotton bandage. This skin is much more sensitive and will burn faster.

Lay the moist side of the plaster across the person's chest and/or upper back. Leave it in place for 10- 30 minutes No longer! This will likely promote sweating and red- dening of the skin so you will need to lift up the corners of the plaster from time to time to make sure the skin is not too red. If the person experiences any discomfort, promptly remove and rinse the skin with tepid water and soap. Give plenty of liquids during the procedure and encourage a warm shower afterwards and then bundle up and take a rest for a least ½ hour..

(A mustard plaster is a time honored therapy. Your great-grandmother may have used mustard plasters to treat coughs, congestion, bronchitis, or pneumonia. A mustard plaster works mainly by increasing circulation, stimulating perspiration and bringing warmth and comfort to congested lungs.)



Mustard Footbath

Used to draw out headaches or migraines and to increase circulation.

Fill a bucket (that you can put both feet into) with warm water. Fill the blender with mustard seeds and blend until the seeds are powdery. Put the mustard powder into the water and stir until blended with the water. Place feet and legs up to the knee, if possible, then cover the legs and bucket with a large towel or flannel sheet. Leave the feet in the water just until the skin starts to 'sting' (about 15 minutes) depending how sensitive the skin is.

Take one foot out of the bucket at a time, wash the leg and foot in a downwards movement with soap and water, taking care to clean well between the toes. Dry legs and feet; apply oil using downward strokes. Put on warm wool socks and rest.

In Our Own Words *by Matthew Sicher*

Choosing to learn the language and culture of ones own home or people is the beginning of a journey that can be tremendously empowering and healing. Once I committed myself to gaining fluency in the Pennsylvania German dialect, a profound transformation took place. All of a sudden I actually felt *at home* in my home.

Before integrating this language of my land and my people into my life, I loved my home, but I perceived the culture as something outside of myself. I now see myself as part of a historical continuum, I am aware that I am part of something much larger than myself. This awareness thus becomes a guiding factor in the decisions I make in my life. I see how the great efforts of countless generations before me are the very imprints of my bones. I gain solace from the knowledge that even the gravest of decisions any of us have to face have already been experienced by the elders who have laid the foundation stones of our lives.

Each language necessarily contributes subtle and unique perspectives to the speaker that may not exist outside of the worldview afforded by that language. As we speak, write, and think in a language, we have only a certain range of words to choose from to communicate the world around us, and our experience of it. These words then influence how we are able (or at least likely) to understand our lives.

For instance, in English we refer to the season following Summer as “Fall”, and in the dialect a common word for that time is “Der Herbst”. That word can mean, “Fall”, but it can also be used to mean, “harvest”. In a culture with strong agricultural roots, among a people considered master farmers for generations, the idea of Autumn is inseparable from the need for harvest. Even amongst dialect speakers who are not agriculturalists, this word for “harvest” is consistently used to refer to “the Fall”. In the worldview made possible through the Pennsylvania German dialect, we are reminded of our people’s longstanding connection with the land and our cultural tradition land-based living.

The Pennsylvania German people and our history cannot be separated from our language. Our language should never be separated from the people. Especially as caretakers and practitioners of a folk healing arts practice, we have a sacred duty to not only understand the tradition of Braucherei, but also the role that Braucherei has played in context of the culture as a whole. In delving ever deeper into the identity of the PA German culture, it becomes evident what a central role the dialect has played in our identity as a people. There have been Brauchers with whom we have trained who would not only speak solely in the dialect to pass on the training, but would also only talk to us *about* Braucherei in the dialect. If we did not know the dialect, they could not trust our intentions with the precious healing tradition.

Committing oneself to intentionally embodying and passing-on traditional knowledge is good work. Everyone has heard the adage that, “those who do not know their history are doomed to repeat it.” I posit that when it comes to the ongoing understanding of folk-culture, one ought indeed be aware of history, and *also* choose some aspect of their folk culture to learn and integrate into modern life. The experience of learning and practicing a folk art or language can become a lifelong practice. The act of first inquiring into, then learning and personally refining an aspect of one’s culture that is otherwise endangered is truly valuable and inspiring. It is through this commitment that we take our place in the long and unbroken line, which links all those who have come before us with all those yet to come. Every generation needs to be the bridge to the next. Our thoughts, decisions, and actions in this life have profound effect on the fate of those souls who are yet to be born. I choose to embody the mother tongue of my Grandfather, so that my grandchildren might have the option to do the same.

We are not alone. We never have been alone and never will be. We have but to speak and listen. The words and deeds of our elders are not lost, just as the words and deeds of our lives are the foundation upon which generations to come will stand. We ought to give the children to come as intact a body of wisdom as we are able, they will need as many tools as possible in the world rising to meet them.

Be it the will of Holy Spirit, may we never forget the wisdom ways of our ancestors, and may the words of our Grandmothers never be alien to our ears. May generations to come continue anon to utter this same prayer with earnest sincerity in their hearts.

Amen

SPINNING THE FLAX TALE...continued from page 13

.....the protection and fertility of the flax crop and the women, the teaching of spinning and weaving and finally, the spinning of threads of fate, creation and destruction. Spinning the thread could be compared to stirring the soup pot. Starting with seemingly nothing and creating something of great worth and usefulness to the folk. The spinning work contained all of the symbolism of the creation cycle: the beginning creative spark, the living, active work and then the 'harvest', completion or fulfillment of the worthy task. With the death of the plant, came the birth of the seeds for the next years' planting and the beginning of a new cycle. It was these deeply held beliefs that insured that all phases of the flax culture were honored equally and thus were rich with tradition and ritual.

Most ritual practices took place during the flax growing season to assure that the plants grew as tall as possible; for the longest lengths of raw fiber made for a stronger thread which was then woven into cloth that was longer lasting. The rituals which focused directly on the fertility and productive health of the fields fell naturally on the women of the village; From the manner in which flax seeds were sown, to the frequent visits to the flax fields during the growing season, the women were solely responsible for these rituals.

Later, during the act of spinning, a woman would soon discover that listening to the rhythmic hum of the wheel and watching it circle round and around in front of the open fire, could induce altered states of consciousness. This was (and is) a perfect meditative exercise for the long dark nights of winter when contemplative thought and dreaming the future was all considered to be part of the 'woman's winter work'.

Because the gifts of the flax plant were considered to be overseen by so many beneficial goddesses, it was also a commonly held belief that the blue blossoms, the seeds and the fine linen cloth were strong deterrents to evil sorcery and witchcraft. These parts of the plant were routinely used in healing and protection ceremonies throughout the Middle Ages. A healing plant poultice was made that much more powerful by utilizing linen in the dressing. Many healing women also had special headdresses made of linen and wore them as a defense against demons.

In fairly recent times, the healthful benefits of flax seeds and flax seed oil have become common knowledge. The Omega 3 fatty acids in the flax seed oil help to 'ward off' the evils of heart disease and cancer and will reduce inflammation within the body, the source of many ills of today.

The seeds (made into a 'slimy' tea by combining 1 cup of boiling water and 3 tsp of seeds) have demulcent and emollient abilities that will soothe coughs and sore throats, or help ease dry constipation and urinary or digestive system inflammation.

Flax seed that has been cooked in milk or water and then used as a poultice will have a drawing effect: For bronchitis, pneumonia or asthma use as a chest plaster with mustard powder (see page 13) or combined with grated carrot and marshmallow root for swellings or inflammation. A warm flax seed poultice will also draw a boil or abscess to a head.

We may think of flax today as a 'new age' or 'natural' remedy but in understanding the incredible significance of the existence of flax in cultures worldwide for the past 25,000 years, the historic uses can be safely and successfully utilized and appreciated by families and practitioners yet today. Certainly makes one writer wistfully imagine a large waving blue patch out back. When my gifted seeds arrive in the mail, I will certainly enjoy creating a new 'tossing and stomping' ritual of my very own.

*Heartfelt thanks to Lu for the initial 'spark' for this article; to Patricia for the 'fuel' and the promise of seed, but mostly to all the Spinning Sisters everywhere who unabashedly rip it out and start it all over again...



A few of Susan's yet-to-be-identified Pennsylvania ancestors...



...Spring Cleaning continued from page 5

I own a vacuum cleaner but I must admit that I use it infrequently. For me, nothing gets the 'dust flying' better than getting the broom out! I feel a quiet satisfaction, mentally and physically, in cleaning up with a broom. It provides good aerobic exercise to give the throw rugs a beating with it.

I recently came across an old daily household chore list for the Dietsch housewife and it stirred some early memories of women I knew who ran their household on such a schedule:

Monday...Wash Day

TuesdayMending and Ironing

Wednesday...Clean Upstairs

Thursday...Clean Downstairs

Friday ...Baking Day

Saturday... Market Day

Twenty five years ago, as a young 'haus-fraa' (lady of the house) I thought this system too rigid and old fashioned for my tastes, but today I will acknowledge a certain appreciation in having household rhythms, no matter how small or elaborate.

I also appreciate certain frugal and old fashioned standards when it comes to household cleaning supplies. With an abundant assortment of expensive chemical and antibacterial products available on the marketplace, I have made a conscious choice to utilize a few safer, more ecologically (and economically) prudent methods of cleaning this year. The following is a basic list of simple ingredients that can provide an arsenal of cleaning products that any 'hausfraa' would be proud to use!

*A large Wife and
a big Barn bring luck to
any Man!*

The PA German dialect translation on page 5

BAKING SODA (sodium bicarbonate): An all-purpose, non-toxic cleaner. Cleans, deodorizes, removes stains and softens fabrics.

BORAX (sodium borate): A natural mineral that kills mold and bacteria. An alternative to bleach, it deodorizes, removes stains

CASTILE and VEGETABLE OIL BASED SOAPS: Cleans everything!

CORNSTARCH: Starches clothes, absorbs oil and grease

HERBS and ESSENTIAL OILS: For disinfecting and fragrance, lavender and rosemary to name a few.

LEMON JUICE: Cuts through grease and removes perspiration and other stains from clothing. A bleach alternative.

SALT can be used as an abrasive

TOOTHPASTE A mild abrasive

WHITE VINEGAR: Great all-purpose cleaner, cuts grease, removes stains and is an excellent water softener. Simply dilute with water.

WASHING SODA (sodium carbonate): Cleans clothes, softens water, cuts grease and disinfects. Increases the cleaning power of soap



Kutztown Area Historical Society

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www.kutztownhistory.org

Der Braucherei Weg “the Braucherei Path”

One of the biggest problems we have come to face in our research and revival of the Braucherei tradition has been the training of new Brauchers. One issue is that we truly need to educate and train many new Brauchers in order to ensure the survival of the practice. On the other hand, however, we simply cannot train new practitioners indiscriminately. In an effort to fulfill several of our goals at once....namely educating as many as possible *about* the tradition, and creating a pool of eligible apprentices who would be able to *carry on* the tradition... we have created a full year course in the history, evolution, and theory of the Braucherei tradition.

This course will provide an overview of the history and evolution of the unique spiritual and healing traditions of the PA Germans. Students will explore the historical roots of Braucherei from Pre-Christian times to the present. In particular they will focus on the evolution of the mystical cosmology through the many waves of cultural influence in both Europe and America. Students will explore the relationship between the rural nature of the PA German people and the structure and function of the Braucherei tradition. They will also survey the theory and practices of Braucherei. Most importantly, students will engage in an active discussion of the ongoing resystemization of this living but severely fragmented tradition.

Those hoping to become apprentices in the Braucherei tradition through the Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts will be required first to complete this year-long course. There are several reasons for this: 1) the year long course will provide us the opportunity to acquaint ourselves well with each student, and their potential strengths and weaknesses as Brauchers; 2) the course will be designed to give students a complete understanding of the cultural and historical context of this tradition, and thus its value as an asset to the culture; 3) the year long cycle of the course will begin students on a spiritual journey that may or may not result in apprenticeship, but will aim to bring each member of the class group to a place of greater self reflection, 4) the course will endeavor to engage students in the process of cultural reclamation and revival.

‘Der Braucherei Weg’ course will be held at the Kutztown Historical Society in Kutztown, PA
Class Dates are: Feb 9, March 8, April 12, May 10, June 14, July 19, Aug. 9, Sept 6, Oct 4, Nov 8, Dec 13, Jan 2009 TBA. The cost for the course will be \$700 for the year. For more information, or to register call Jesse at 484-336-4611.

****This course will also be digitally recorded and available for Distance Learning. If you are interested please inquire to the number above.**

Course Goals:

- Introduce students to the history and evolution of PA German Mysticism, occult wisdom, and healing practices
- Introduce students to the theory and cosmology of the Braucherei tradition
- Acquaint students with the scope of the Braucherei tradition by sharing prominent beliefs and practices of the tradition
- Engage students in an active dialog about folk cultural evolution
- Prepare students for future apprenticeship in the Braucherei tradition should they choose to pursue it.

The curriculum will include:

- Pre-Christian history and contributions to the tradition from the Roman, Celtic, and Germanic peoples
- Jewish and early Christian influence on the tradition
- German Mysticism of the middle ages
- Greek influence upon the tradition
- History and Mystical traditions of the reformation
- Early Pennsylvania Braucherei
- Native American influence
- Twentieth century Braucherei
- Differentiation between Braucherei and Hexerei
- The decline of Braucherei- Industrialization, Hex Trials, World Wars 1 and 2
- Cultural revival
- Survey of the current day tradition
- Cosmology and world view of modern day Brauchers
- Physical prayers
- Visual prayers
- Prayers in the world of spirit
- Folk herbal tradition
- New trends in Braucherei and the ongoing resystemization of the tradition

Exploring the Fine Art of..... **HOMESTEAD HERBALISM**

~An eight month foundation course~

In the not too distant past, keeping a family strong and healthy with simple home remedies was a common homesteading skill that every woman possessed. Identifying and utilizing wild and cultivated plants was as important and necessary as preserving food for the winter months or learning to stitch.

The "Homestead Herbalism" foundation course was designed to gather small groups of women (and yes, a few men!) with the intent of re-introducing this empowering tradition by learning together, using our hands, and preparing and sharing the herbal harvest.

Farm at Coventry's informative eight month "Homestead Herbalism" foundation course meets one Saturday every month from March through October. The course curriculum weaves informative current herbal wisdom with interesting historical facts and folk traditions. Through the seasons, from planting through harvest, we will learn to create delicious, nutritional snacks as well as therapeutic preparations using edible, medicinal and fragrance herbs that are both cultivated and wild crafted. Our time together will give students basic herbal knowledge and skills that will empower them to use herbs for their own nutritional, therapeutic and creative needs. Our teaching areas include a cozy classroom/farmhouse herb kitchen, cultivated gardens on our farm and the fields and forests of northern Chester County, Pennsylvania.

Students will receive approx. 56 hours of instruction, a large spiral ring notebook, abundant instructional hand-outs and recipes and a wide variety of take-home herbal preparations made together in class. A beautiful certificate will be presented at the completion of the course.

The curriculum includes but is not limited to:

- *Identifying and utilizing common backyard and wild plants
- *Planting, Harvesting, Wild-crafting, Drying, Preservation and Storage
- *Using herbs as Foods, Tonics and Medicines
- *Learn the Fine Art of Tea Making- exploring Infusions & Decoctions
- *Experiencing Tasty and Nutritious Herbal Treats and Recipes
- *Large spiral ring notebook containing 50+ in-depth Plant Specific study sheets
- *Herbal Glossary, Book Recommendations, Networking and Resources
- *Simple Overview of Body Systems and Therapeutics for the:
 - *Digestive System
 - *Nervous System
 - *Circulatory System
 - *Immune System
 - *Female Reproductive System
- *Topical Applications: Poultices, Compresses and Plasters
- *Time in the kitchen: teas, infused oils, salves, syrups, cordials and more
- *Herbal First Aid Kit/Kitchen Cabinet Remedies
- *Preparing for the Cold and Flu Season



For more detailed information
or to register for the course, visit
www.FarmatCoventry.com
or call 610-469-9591

***Meeting one Saturday per month beginning in March 2008 from 9am to 4pm
Dates: March 15, April 19, May 17, June 7, July 12, August 16, September 13, and October 11
(dates are tentative and may be subject to change)

The cost for the course is \$700 with a \$100 non-refundable deposit required. Payment plans are available

Hollerbeier Haven Guild Gatherings in Kutztown, PA

February 23rd- Life Transitions: Braucherei Ceremonies in Daily Life The Braucherei tradition includes ceremonies for nearly every conceivable life transition. At this gathering we will focus on the various transitional ceremonies (ie: Birth, coming of age, Death, etc), their traditional use and variation, and how we can incorporate these traditions into our modern lives. We will discuss the wholeness and harmony that the presence of ceremony and ritual can bring to our daily lives.

March 29th- Spirits of Braucherei During this gathering we will focus on the many saints, angels, and helping spirits invoked in various prayers and healing practices of the Braucherei tradition. We will delve into the evolution of these spirits and their historical and cultural importance to the Germanic peoples. We will also discuss the character of each in depth, and the roles they still play in Braucherei healing and in our daily lives.

April 26th- The German Mystics -This gathering will focus on the teachings and contributions of the German mystics. In particular we will discuss the teachings of the Gnostics, Hildegard von Bingen, Meister Eckhart, Johannes Tauler and the Friends of God, Cornelius Heinrich Agrippa, Paracelsus, Jacob Boehme, and Johannes Kelpius. We will also discuss issues of spirituality surrounding the time of the reformation. We will explore the impact of these factors, teachers, and leaders had on the evolution of the Braucherei tradition.

May 31st- Tools and Techniques of Braucherei May's guild gathering will focus on the various tools and objects used in Braucherei's traditional ceremonies. We will discuss the objects themselves: their historical usage, symbolic meaning, and implementation in modern Braucherei practice.

June 28th- Blanzeschwetze- "Speaking with Plants" In June Jesse and Susan will join together to discuss the Braucherei practice of "Blanzeschwetze" (speaking with plants). They will also discuss the ritual use of herbs in Braucherei. There are several medicinal herbs that are particularly important to the PA German healing tradition. Susan and Jesse will explain in depth about some of these plants: their character, cultural significance, and use in medicine and healing ceremony.

***All Gatherings will be held at the Kutztown Historical Society from 10-3pm \$35 members/\$45 non-members. To register fill out the enclosed form, call Jesse at 484-336-4611 or visit www.ThreeSistersCenter.com**

Herbal Hands Workshops and Classes in Pottstown, PA

Saturday, March 1: Dreaming the Herbal Garden-Part One Use the winter months wisely by creating a thorough spring and summer garden plan now! We will discuss: defining your vision, basics of garden design, overview of annual and perennial herbs, resources for research, planning, seeds and herb plants. Part of this class will be structured for sharing and inspiration so please come with your specific questions and ideas, seed catalogs, gardening magazines, sketches & photos, if you have them. You'll go home with abundant handouts, a checklist for garden planning to work on at home and a small herb garden journal to organize all of your ideas. A follow-up evening class for **Dreaming the Herbal Garden -Part Two** in April will be discussed and planned with students who wish to: share their finished plans, have more individualized and detailed Q&A, plan an herb shopping field trip in May, and more.

Saturday, April 5th: Spring House Cleaning- Natural Ways to Clean your Home on Every Level! By simple blending of inexpensive household ingredients, essential oils and herbs we can easily create a wide variety of non-toxic cleaning products that are healthy for humans, pets and the environment. We will also discuss various ways to cleanse your body and space of psychic 'dirt', how to create sacred space, clearing ideas for moving into or out of a home, and 'clearing the air' after a disagreement. Vow to give your home a thorough cleaning this spring! Resource materials, supplies list and recipes will be provided. We will also make a 'room purifier' to take home.

Saturday, May 3: Building an Herbal Apothecary Work through the spring and summer to steadily and confidently create your own herbal apothecary by growing (and/or gathering) the proper supplies in order to keep your family healthy during the fall and winter months. Topics will include: discussion of basic antiviral, antibacterial and tonic herbs, making a natural first aid travel kit, and the basics of kitchen cabinet medicine. As always, abundant handouts will be provided.

Saturday June Date TBA: The Subtle Power of Rose-Therapeutic Uses of the Mythic Flower of Love. The damask roses will be in high bloom for this class! Learn about the myth and mystery surrounding the beloved rose. We will immerse ourselves with the fragrance, tastes and therapeutic uses of roses and create wonderful take home gifts utilizing fresh rose petals. Come prepared to experience the rose on a deep level. Handouts will include resource materials for growing roses organically, where to purchase your own fragrant heritage rose bushes and abundant recipes. Wear something pink or red if you can!!

**** All Herbal Hands Workshops will be held at the Farm at Coventry from 10-3pm and cost \$40 .**

To register fill out the enclosed form, call Susan at 610-469-9591 or visit

www.FarmatCoventry.com

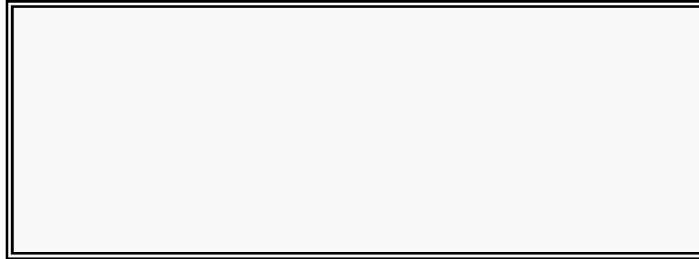
Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts

New mailing address!

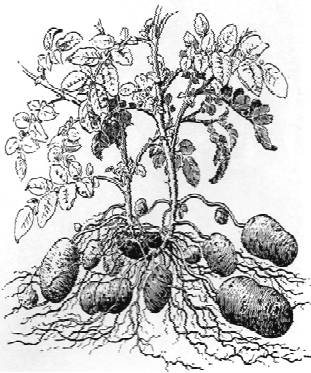
PO Box 88

Kempton, PA

19529



Visit our website: www.ThreeSistersCenter.com



A Collection of Old Time Wart Cures

Some unusual and mysterious wart cures that have been used through the ages...

- Cut a potato in half and rub the wart with the potato. Then bury the potatoes under the rain spout. When the potato rots, the wart will be gone
- Take an equal amount of brown soap and saliva and mix the two together to make a plaster. Apply to the warts and leave on for 24 hours. Repeat again if necessary but when removed the warts will come off.
- Tie a human hair around the wart and leave it in place for a few days. Remove the hair and place it in a hole in a living tree. When the hair rots the wart will disappear.
- Put the drops of milkweed juice (or dandelion juice or celandine juice) on the wart throughout the summer months. The wart will fall off before frost.
- 'Buy the wart' from somebody by giving them a penny. Be kind and do not pass the wart-penny off to an unsuspecting person. Bury the penny in the dirt